and, two days later, the government of Bhutan issued a formal diplomatic démarche to Beijing via the Chinese embassy in New Delhi, protesting China's incursion.

On 29 June, Bhutan protested again to the Chinese government, which on the same day released a map depicting the plateau as part of China. As evidence to support their claim, the Chinese referred to a border treaty signed by the Chinese and the British in 1890, which they claimed had been recognized by Jawaharlal Nehru. But that treaty defined only the northern part of the Sikkim-Tibet border, not the Sikkim-Tibet-Bhutan tri-border junction.[62] Meanwhile, India moved troops into Sikkim to strengthen its defences in the general border area. The stand-off heightened tensions along the border to a level not seen since the 1962 War.

Manu Balachandaran and Harish C. Menon, two Indian writers, wrote in an article on the website *Quartz India* that the issue was more than just a localized border dispute. 'China is testing the India-Bhutan relationship', they argued. 'If and when India falters, China will be waiting with open arms to take Bhutan into its fold, especially since the tiny country is now pursuing an independent foreign policy after decades of outsourcing it to India.'[63]

Bhutan was caught in a dilemma. On the one hand, relations with India are crucial for the country's economy, foreign trade, and defence, but, on the other, Thimphu cannot afford to antagonize its powerful northern neighbour. On 1 August, Bhutan's ambassador to India, Vetsop Namgyel, surprised the diplomatic community in New Delhi by attending a function at the Chinese embassy in the Indian capital to mark the 90th anniversary of the founding of the People's Liberation Army. His appearance at the event was highly remarkable, as Bhutan and China do not have diplomatic relations. But, as a commentator in a regional publication wrote at the time, it should be seen 'a subtle signal of Bhutanese goodwill to China'.[64]

The crisis was eventually resolved at the end of August, but India and China announced their respective decisions to withdraw troops from the Doklam Plateau in vastly different ways. In a statement on 28 August, India's Ministry of External Affairs said the 'expeditious disengagement of border personnel at the face-off site at Doklam has been agreed to and is ongoing'.[65] On the other hand, Xinhua, China's official news agency, announced that India had withdrawn its personnel and equipment 'that had